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Infectious HISTORY

2003 WHO issues a global alert for SARS. H3N2 virus in Fujian, China, and mad cow virus in the US give the world brief scares. Bird flu surfaces in Vietnam and Thailand.

2006 The H5N1 virus hits India but subsides by the end of the year.

2008 A fresh strain of bird flu strikes India. Thousands of chickens are found infected in West Bengal.

2009 H1N1 flu surfaces in March in Mexico. WHO says it is a global pandemic.

shortfalls is not a realistic possibility.

Diabetes, cancer, cardiovascular diseases, and hypertension represent the next tidal wave of health issues looming on the global horizon. Non-communicable diseases currently account for two-thirds of all deaths worldwide, and are projected to account for three-quarters of all deaths by 2030. Cardiovascular diseases were responsible for 17 million deaths in 2004 worldwide. The rising burden of cancer is proved by the increase in new cases each year—from an estimated 10 million new cases in 2000 to 13 million new cancer cases in 2009. This number is projected to increase to nearly 17 million in 2020.

Major modifiable risk factors for non-communicable diseases have already reached epidemic proportions, with a global estimate of 300 million obese people and an additional 700 million who are simply overweight. In the US, it is estimated that over 70 per cent of the adult popula-

THE NEW MILLENNIUM HAS SEEN THE EMERGENCE OF NEW STRAINS OF INFLUENZA

tion is overweight or obese. But these conditions are not limited exclusively to the developed countries. Low and middle-income countries also face this threat. For example, over 50 million Indians aged 20 and above have diabetes and the number is projected to rise to 87 million by 2030. The prevalence of diabetes and hypertension in the developing world is approaching rates found in the US and other developed countries. The world is facing a double burden of disease in which there are as many people overweight as there are hungry.

Use of tobacco is another major risk factor for non-communicable diseases. The past decade has seen an increase in smokers and a shift in where these smokers live, from the US and Europe to China and other emerging economies. The number of smokers in China (320 million) is as large as the population of the US, and the

THE LAST CENTURY was driven by machines. This century will be driven by healthcare.

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